

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

The millionaires I know are like Larry, a retired insurance professional our team got to know during our millionaire study. Like many of the people we talked to, Larry came from humble beginnings. His parents were Wisconsin dairy farmers who had never gone past the eighth grade. They were hard workers who hated debt—and they taught their children to hate debt, as well. Becoming the first person in his family to graduate college, Larry left the dairy farm and began a thirty-five-year career in insurance. Throughout his working years, Larry kept his spending in check, just like his parents taught him. He avoided all forms of debt except a mortgage, saying, “I never buy anything I can’t afford to pay cash for.”

He and his wife lived well below their means throughout their marriage, making saving money a priority from Larry’s first full-time paycheck. Even when he was only making \$5,500 a year early in his career, he still prioritized saving and managed to set aside \$100 a month. When he got a raise, he increased his savings. When he got an annual bonus, he saved it. When his company introduced the 401(k), Larry maxed it out. He never played around with debt, and he never got distracted by risky investments that others tried to push on him. He worked hard, stuck to his plan, drove old paid-for cars, and didn’t pay any attention to what other people had. The end result? He retired early at age fifty-five and has a current net worth of over \$4.2 million. Now he gets to travel, play golf and tennis several times a week, visit his children and grandkids whenever he wants, and enjoy long walks and bike rides with his wife. He absolutely loves his life, and he knows one stupid investment decision or car loan could have cost him big-time.

There will always be new investments, opportunities, and strategies that promise the world but will most likely lead you further away from millionaire status. If there’s one thing I’ve learned from the millionaires we studied, it’s that shortcuts are for suckers. The long road may not get you there as quickly as you want, but it *will* get you there.